Medical Emoji

A Briefing for the American Medical Informatics Association (AMIA)

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The opportunity in one paragraph

Emoji are the most widely used visual language in human history — present on virtually every phone, in every messaging app, in patient texts, portal messages, public-health campaigns, and, increasingly, the clinical record itself. Yet the medical vocabulary is nearly empty: there is no kidney, no liver, no stomach, no EKG. Standardized medical emoji are, at bottom, **clinical iconography** — a controlled-vocabulary, interoperability, and patient-communication problem, which is squarely AMIA's domain. Our team changed this once: in 2020 we helped add the **anatomical heart (🫀)** and **lungs (🫁)** to the global Unicode Standard. We are now pursuing the next slate of clinically essential symbols and asking AMIA to lend the credibility of the national informatics body to the effort.

Track record — this has been done before

- **2020 — anatomical heart (🫀) and lungs (🫁) approved** and shipped in Unicode Emoji 13.0; the first anatomically accurate internal-organ emoji, now rendering on Apple, Google, Samsung, and Microsoft platforms worldwide (Apple shipped them in iOS 14.2).
- Led by a physician team out of Massachusetts General Hospital, working through the official Unicode Consortium proposal process.
- Coverage and recognition: Boston Globe, The Verge, Harvard Medical School, and — most relevant to informatics — STAT's January 2026 report that emoji are now turning up in clinical records far more than they used to.

This is not a concept pitch. It is the extension of a proven, peer-recognized success.

The evidence base

- **JAMA (2021)** — the clinical rationale for standardized medical emoji. https://jamanetwork.com/journals/jama/fullarticle/2783847
- **JAMA (2022)** — an emoji-based pain scale matched the standard numeric rating scale. https://jamanetwork.com/journals/jama/fullarticle/2794067
- **JAMA Network Open (2023)** — the case for a comprehensive set. https://jamanetwork.com/journals/jamanetworkopen/fullarticle/2805970
- Specialty-journal support in **Hepatology** (liver) and **The Spine Journal** (spine).

The consistent argument: standardized medical symbols improve clarity in patient communication, support health literacy across language and literacy barriers, and give clinicians and public-health communicators a shared, universally rendered visual shorthand.

The concepts we are submitting in August 2026

This year's submission completes the **core anatomy — kidney, liver, stomach, and spine — plus white blood cell and EKG.** Each maps to a high-burden condition and a clear communication use case (chronic kidney disease, liver disease, GI disorders, low back pain, infection/immunity, and cardiovascular disease). We also maintain a broader reference set and a comprehensive medical-emoji site so the field has a single, authoritative home.

Why AMIA, specifically

- **Emoji are a standards problem, and AMIA lives in standards.** Approving a clinically reviewed symbol set into the Unicode Standard is a controlled-vocabulary and interoperability question — the same family of work (terminologies, data standards, patient-facing communication) AMIA advances every day.
- **Health literacy, telehealth, and cross-language communication** are core AMIA priorities, and that is precisely the clinical case for medical emoji: interoperable, plain-language symbols that render identically across every device, portal, and platform.
- **Unicode rewards exactly what AMIA can credibly attest to:** evidence of real-world usage *and* a recognized authority affirming that a symbol is important and well-defined. The national informatics body is an ideal source of the second.

Organized medicine is already behind this

We hold formal letters of support from, among others: the **American College of Emergency Physicians (ACEP)** — a *project-wide* endorsement of all the concepts; the **American Gastroenterological Association** and the **American Society for Gastrointestinal Endoscopy**; and a nephrology coalition including the **American Society of Nephrology, International Society of Nephrology, National Kidney Foundation, KDIGO, AAKP**, and roughly a dozen more. The full list is at medicalemoji.org/endorsements. What we do not yet have is the voice of **organized informatics** — the discipline that owns clinical iconography, interoperability, and patient communication. That is precisely what AMIA is.

How Unicode works — and what an AMIA letter actually does

Unicode approves new emoji through a formal proposal process with two pillars: (1) **evidence of expected high-frequency, real-world usage** — which we build ourselves, and which society letters explicitly do *not* count toward; and (2) **credibility and clarity** — that the symbol is well-defined, distinct, and that recognized authorities consider it meaningful. An AMIA letter does its work on the second pillar and beyond it: it signals to the Unicode Emoji Subcommittee that the national body for biomedical and health informatics considers a standardized clinical emoji set important and legitimate, and it positions informatics — and Unicode — for a standing partnership on clinically accurate symbols over time.

To be candid about scope: a single letter will not, by itself, guarantee any specific approval. Its value is credibility, signaling, and the door it opens. The frequency evidence and proposal drafting remain our job.

What we are asking of AMIA

One AMIA-level letter of support, modeled on the ACEP letter, that:

1. Affirms the clinical-informatics, interoperability, and health-literacy value of a standardized set of medical emoji; and
2. Encourages the Unicode Consortium to consider these concepts and to engage organized informatics as an ongoing partner on clinically accurate symbols.

This does **not** ask AMIA to draft proposals, fund the work, or take on ongoing obligations — we handle the Unicode submissions, evidence, and artwork. A turnkey draft letter is attached; AMIA should feel free to edit it freely, place it on AMIA letterhead, and choose the right signatory.

Timing

Date	What
July 17, 2026	World Emoji Day — the natural public moment to release letters of support.
July 31, 2026	Unicode's posted intake deadline for the current proposal cycle.
August 1, 2026	Our working deadline to have all letters of support in hand.

Anything AMIA is comfortable lending by **mid-July** would be ideal — but there is no pressure, and we will move at whatever pace and process the Board prefers.

Next steps

We are glad to present to the AMIA Board or the relevant committee (public policy / standards), in person or by video; to provide the full library of existing support letters, JAMA and specialty-journal publications, and draft Unicode proposals for review; and to move entirely at the Association's pace.

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